



Bulls rampage: The Chennai Bulls emerged as the inaugural champion of the Rugby Premier League, thrashing the Delhi Redz 41-0 in a one-sided final in Mumbai. AFP

India isn't yet commercialised, it's played in over 250 districts.

"Globally, it's aspirational. In some countries, rugby is a private school sport while football is played in public schools. But in India, rugby defies these boundaries — it's played both in urban hubs like Mumbai and in rural belts," Trivedi explained.

The RPL has also attracted serious backers. Groups like Manipal and Dream11 now own teams, while corporate sponsorships have started to trickle in. Weather-related disruptions led to thin turnouts at the Andheri Sports Complex, but the league found substantial traction via broadcast. Looking ahead, expansion is key. Team owners believe the RPL shouldn't remain Mumbai-centric.

"This sport deserves to reach new cities," said Sanjith Shetty, co-owner of Bengaluru Bravehearts and a former rugby player himself.

For Shetty and others, the

investment isn't short-term.

"We've seen startups evolve. Nothing big happens in the first few years. This is a long-term vision," he said.

Yet infrastructure remains a concern. While Mumbai can host a league of this magnitude, the same isn't true for Kolkata or Odisha. Grounds exist, but purpose-built rugby stadiums do not. Bose and the federation are hopeful that the RPL's steady start will help build momentum — and facilities.

On the field, the players have already started reaping benefits.

"Earlier, people would ask, 'Kya khelte ho?' They didn't even know rugby existed," said India captain Mohit Khatri. "But the RPL has given us visibility. That's invaluable."

He's also optimistic about the ripple effect.

"In the past, getting jobs was tough for rugby players. But with the sport gaining traction and government backing for athletes,

our boys now stand a chance at public sector jobs too," Khatri noted. "We used to play maybe three matches a year. Now, the more we play, the better we'll get."

International coaches agree. Mike Friday, head coach of the Kalinga Black Tigers and a respected name in global rugby, spent extensive time with Indian players and noted rapid development.

"Earlier, their skills weren't really tested. But playing alongside elite athletes forces them to respond to real-game scenarios. That's how you grow," Friday said.

Of course, there were teething troubles — rains dampened crowds, publicity was underwhelming, and the sport still has miles to go in breaking into the mainstream. But despite it all, the RPL has delivered something invaluable: belief.

For players like Javed and Khatri, the league isn't just a tournament — it's proof that their dreams have a place in the sun.